

Research Note: Robert Bock's "Rochester Circle"

By Ryan E. Bock (Originally Published: August 19, 2023; Last Updated: December 13, 2025)

This research note highlights the role played by Gustav Bock (1833-1899), Jacob Mailänder (1824-1889), and William Schroeder (1840-1926) in helping Robert Bock (1840-1893) become a naturalized U.S. citizen and, ultimately, a Kansas homesteader who paved the way for the subsequent immigration of his younger brother Ottomar Bock (1845-1909) and his family. Robert knew all three men well during his years in Rochester, New York (c. 1867-1872).

The Witness Party

On October 16, 1871, Robert Bock took an important step in his American journey by becoming a naturalized U.S. citizen in a courthouse in Rochester, New York. Standing with him were two witnesses, both German-born and naturalized U.S. citizens who had made Rochester their home: 38-year-old Gustav Bock and 47-year-old Jacob Mailänder. Under oath, both men testified that they were "well acquainted with" Robert and knew him to be "a man of good moral character" who had satisfied the residency requirements for citizenship.¹

Though they came from different backgrounds and arrived at different times, the three men shared notable parallels in their immigration experiences:

- Jacob Mailänder emigrated from Württemberg, Germany, in 1854² and by 1860 he had established himself as a carpenter in Rochester.³
- Gustav Bock, who should not be confused with Robert Bock's younger brother (1848-?) of the same name, emigrated in 1860 from Döschnitz, Germany.⁴ He worked primarily as a craftsman during his years in Rochester, beginning as a cooper⁵ and later moving into the trades of carpentry, showcase manufacturing, and cabinetmaking.⁶
- Robert Bock emigrated from Döschnitz in 1865.⁷ He and Gustav may have been distant relatives, given their shared surname and German hometown. Robert worked in Rochester as a butcher,⁸ a trade which he learned in Germany along with his brother, Ottomar.⁹ Robert was also identified as a joiner on the passenger list of his arriving vessel, which suggests the possibility that he may have worked with Jacob and Gustav in this capacity.¹⁰

¹ See Appendix A.

² Jacob arrived in the United States on June 1, 1854 as a passenger aboard the *Jeverland* (NARA, *Passenger Lists*, M237).

³ Jacob appears as a carpenter in the 1860 U.S. Federal Census (NARA, *1860 U.S. Census*, Rochester Ward 5). Additionally, Rochester City Directories confirm that Jacob (listed under the surnames Mylander, Milender, Milander, Mielander, Mailender, and Mailainder) resided at multiple addresses in the years leading up to and after Robert's naturalization ceremony: Hand (1861-?), 83 Kelly (1864-1866), 21 Hanover (1868), 28 Hanover (1869-1883), 36 Hanover (1884-1889) (Rochester Public Library).

⁴ NARA, *Passenger Lists*, M237.

⁵ Gustav is listed as a cooper in the Rochester City Directories of 1866 and 1867. Prior to 1875, he appears in these directories as "Gustave Buck" (Rochester Public Library).

⁶ Gustav appears as a carpenter in the 1870 U.S. Federal Census (Ancestry.com). He is also listed in the Rochester City Directories as a carpenter from 1869-1873 and a showcase manufacturer in 1875 (Rochester Public Library). He first appears in the 1880 U.S. Federal Census as a cabinet maker and is also listed under this profession in Rochester City Directories from 1875 until his death in 1899 (Ancestry.com and The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints; Rochester Public Library).

⁷ Robert arrived in the United States on November 15, 1865, as a passenger aboard the *Electric* (NARA, *Passenger Lists*, M237).

⁸ Robert is listed as a butcher in the Rochester City Directories of 1870 and 1871; in both years he boarded at 48 St. Joseph (Rochester Public Library).

⁹ According to Maxine Bock Mansholt, Ottomar "did a lot of the village butchering [in Döschnitz], making many things of the hog or beef, such as head cheese, liverworst [sic], stuffed sausage, pig foot jelly, and many other things..." (Mansholt 1978).

¹⁰ NARA, *Passenger Lists*, M237.

At the time of Robert's naturalization ceremony, all three men lived on the East side of Rochester within about a mile and a half of each other (See Appendix C). A fourth man, a tailor named William Schroeder, briefly resided with Gustav (his brother-in-law) and likely went on to play a significant role in influencing Robert to migrate to Smith County, Kansas.

From Rochester to Kansas

Gustav Bock (christened as Gustav Carl Wilhelm Bock) was born in Döschnitz, Germany, on March 1, 1833,¹¹ the third of four children to Johann Heinrich Bock (1798-1861) and Johanne Catharine Juliane Bock (née Schoeler) (1800-1870). He departed Hamburg on August 16, 1860, aboard the *Louis Napoleon*, and arrived in New York City on October 4. Within about a year of his arrival, he married Justina Augusta Schroeder (1836-1907). The couple had four children: Emily Bock (1863-?), Edward Bock (1863-1956), Robert W. Bock (1867-1893), and Aurora Bock (1870-1901). Apart from a brief stint as a saloon keeper in 1874, Gustav spent most of his years in Rochester working as a carpenter and cabinetmaker.

While there is no direct evidence of a familial relationship between Gustav and Robert, there are hints of such a connection. In addition to sharing a surname and hometown, Robert clearly relied on Gustav and his family to help establish himself in Rochester, gain naturalized citizenship, and ultimately set out for Kansas to become a homesteader. Gustav and Justina also named their third child Robert, who was born while Robert Bock was living in Rochester. Finally, it is noteworthy that Gustav returned to Germany for a visit in the spring of 1883.¹² While the purpose and details of his trip are unknown, he likely visited his hometown—where he may have crossed paths with Ottomar, who emigrated from Döschnitz in May 1885 with his family to join Robert in Smith County.

From roughly 1866 to 1873, Gustav and Justina resided at 35 Munger Street. Justina's brother, a tailor named William Schroeder, lived with them for several years at this address¹³ before leaving for Smith County, Kansas, in 1871 to become a homesteader.¹⁴ A working theory is that Gustav introduced Robert Bock to William during their overlapping time in Rochester, and that William ultimately inspired Robert to move to Kansas. This appears highly plausible given that Robert filed his homestead claim in Smith County about eight months after William,¹⁵ and the two remained in contact for the rest of their lives. According to Maxine Bock Mansholt, they regularly helped each other break sod to prepare their land for crops.¹⁶ William also served as the executor of Robert's estate after his death in 1893.¹⁷

¹¹ Gustav's date of birth appears in U.S. records as February 28, 1833 (Find a Grave 10549296). By contrast, German Lutheran Church records from Döschnitz list his date of birth as March 1, 1833 (Archion.de).

¹² Staatsarchiv Hamburg.

¹³ William Schroeder is listed as a resident of 35 Munger Street in the Rochester City Directories of 1869 and 1870 (Rochester Public Library).

¹⁴ Lebanon Journal.

¹⁵ William submitted his homestead application on July 13, 1871 (FamilySearch William Shrader); Robert submitted his on March 25, 1872 (FamilySearch Robert Bock).

¹⁶ Mansholt.

¹⁷ Smith County Journal.

Sources

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Wikimedia Commons. "USA Northeast Location Map." SVG file uploaded by DutchTreat. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:USA_Northeast_location_map.svg

Appendix A. "Naturalization Over 18 Years: Robert Bock"¹⁸

Jacob Mailänder and Gustav Bock appear as witnesses at Robert Bock's naturalization ceremony in Rochester, New York, on October 16, 1871.

NATURALIZATION OVER EIGHTEEN YEARS. Printed and Sold by BENTON & ANDREWS, Rochester, N. Y.

State of New-York, } ss. *Jacob Mailänder*
Monroe COUNTY, ss. *Gustav Bock*

of the *City of Rochester* in the County of *Monroe* in the State aforesaid, having been duly sworn, depose and say each for himself that they are citizens of the United States, that they are well acquainted with *Robert Bock* that he has resided in the United States for five years last past, and not elsewhere, and for the last year in the State of New-York, and during all that time has behaved as a man of good moral character, attached to the principles of the Constitution of the United States, and well disposed to the good order and happiness of the same.

Sworn to in open Court, this *16th* day } *Jacob Mailänder*
of *October* 1871, before me, } *Gustav Bock*
B. F. Freeman
Sp. J. Clerk

I, *Robert Bock* do solemnly swear, that I will support the Constitution of the United States, and that I hereby entirely renounce and abjure all allegiance and fidelity to every foreign prince, potentate, state and sovereignty whatever, and particularly to the *Empire* of *Germany* of whom I am a subject. So help me God.

Sworn to in open Court, this *16th* day } *Robert Bock*
of *October* 1871, before me, }
B. F. Freeman
Sp. J. Clerk

State of New-York, } ss. *October 16th 1871*
Monroe COUNTY, ss. *Robert Bock*

In the Matter of the Application of *Robert Bock* to become a citizen of the United States:

The said applicant having made application to this Court to become a citizen of the United States, and it appearing that he, the said applicant, two years since made the declaration required by law; and it appearing to the full satisfaction of this Court that he has complied in all respects with the laws of the United States in relation to naturalization; and the Court being satisfied that the said applicant has resided in the United States for at least five years immediately preceding this application, and that during all that time he has behaved as a man of good moral character, attached to the principles of the Constitution of the United States, and well disposed to the good order and happiness of the same; and the said applicant having appeared in open Court, and taken and subscribed the oath that he will support the Constitution of the United States, and of abjuration required by law: ORDERED, that the said *Robert Bock* be and he is hereby admitted a citizen of the United States, and of any of them.

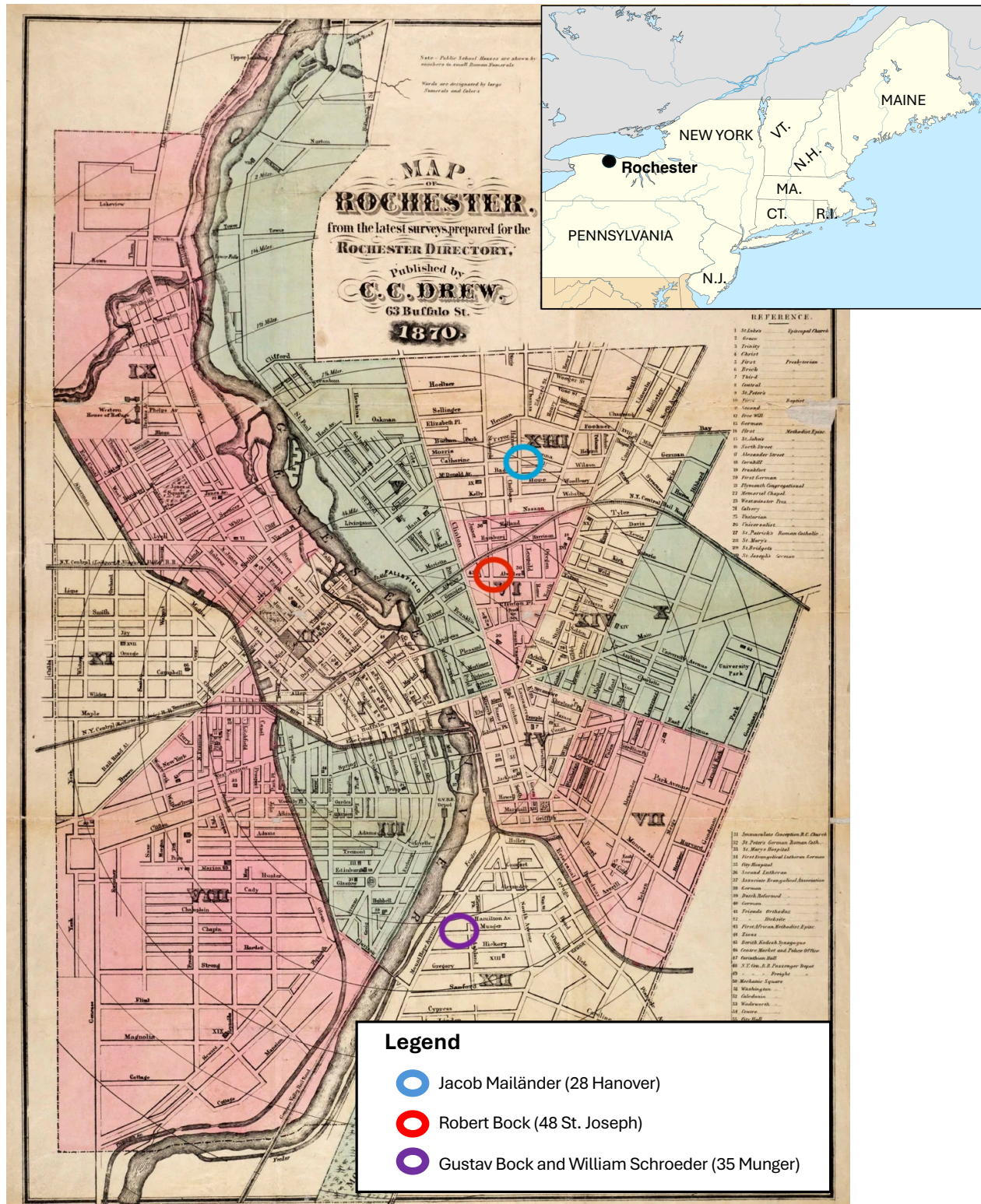
A. G. Mabbett Clerk

Appendix B. Birth and Baptismal Record for Gustav Bock¹⁹

48 Im Jahr					1833 III	
No.	Taufname des Kindes.	Tauf- und Zuname, auch Stadt, Amt, oder Gewerbe des Vaters.	T a u f- und voriger Geschlechtsname der Mutter.	Tag und Stunde der Geburt.	Tag der Taufe, wo sie geschehen und wer sie verrichtet.	Namen der Pathen.
N. 4.	Carl Louis Richard	Herr Carl Heinrich Friedrich Gansert, Leinwandhändler, in Aachen.	Fräulein Friederich Gansert, in Aachen.	Den 21. d. M. 1833, 10 Uhr.	Den 21. d. M. 1833, 10 Uhr.	1. Herr Carl Heinrich Friedrich Gansert, 2. Herr Carl Heinrich Friedrich Gansert, 3. Herr Carl Heinrich Friedrich Gansert.
S. 5.	Carl Wilhelm	Herr Johann Heinrich Gansert, Leinwandhändler, in Aachen.	Fräulein Johanne Caroline Gansert, in Aachen.	Den 21. d. M. 1833, 10 Uhr.	Den 21. d. M. 1833, 10 Uhr.	1. Herr Carl Heinrich Friedrich Gansert, 2. Herr Carl Heinrich Friedrich Gansert, 3. Herr Carl Heinrich Friedrich Gansert.

¹⁹ Gustav's date of birth is shown as March 1, 1833; his date of baptism (christening) is shown as March 10, 1833 (Archion.de).

Appendix C: Rochester, NY Addresses of Gustav Bock, Robert Bock, Jacob Mailänder, and William Schroeder (1869-1871)²⁰



²⁰ Map derived from C.C. Drew, Wikimedia Commons, and residential addresses published in Rochester, NY, City Directories, 1869-1871 (Rochester Public Library).